

JASON MOLLINK

Writing Portfolio

Screenwriter · Interactive Narrative · Essayist



La Biennale di Venezia

Biennale College
Cinema VR

INTERACTIVE
NARRATIVE

The Owl House in VR

A journey through Helen Martin's last day. A shadow armed with Helen's lantern brings light to the forbidden Owl House, revealing the unsettling world of sculpture, longing and quiet rebellion that she built with Koos Malgas, a fragile collaboration shaped by their shared alienation in Apartheid South Africa.

An immersive film set to premiere at the Venice Film Festival after being selected for an intensive mentorship program with the Venice Biennale Immersive Cinema College in 2025.

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Various copy written by me that appeared in the Venice Gap Financing Market Brochure at the 82nd Edition of the Venice Film Festival

Lighting the room reveals a tall, fat man in boxers and a white vest lying on the long bed. On his head is a large box with a depiction of an orange sun. The Little Devil whistles until he gets up and walks to the next room.

BOXMAN

Hhmmph!

Julia's face fades over Boxman's.

JULIA MALGAS NARRATION

Agh, Boxman. You know sometimes you get those people that act like they are blind to the world around them? Ja, Boxman.

Boxman walks into the doorframe before continuing onto the next room.

A Victorian image has an inscription that reads: 'Oh, for the touch of a vanished hand. And the sound of a voice that is still'.

INT. LONG BEDROOM - DAY

The Long Bedroom is multicolored with geometric patterns on the ceiling. Lifting the lantern to another sun illuminates the room and activates a memory.

Helen and Koos paste glass onto the back wall. A glass shard from the top of the wall drifts off, sparkles and falls into Koos's eye.

KOOS MALGAS

Ow! Ow it's in my eye!

HELEN MARTINS

Don't move. I'll bring the water.

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SOUTH AFRICA

OWL HOUSE IN VR JASON MOLLINK

INTERACTIVE/ LIVE PERFORMANCE | DEVELOPMENT



DIRECTOR'S BIOGRAPHY

Jason Mollink is a writer and artist working at the intersection of film, immersive media and video-games. His experimental films have premiered internationally. His work in academia explores the overwhelming presence of images and light in our modern world. He is passionate about immersive tech and South African storytelling, he seeks to foster new kinds of audiences, with critical, curious, and participatory experiences to bring about new kinds of conversation and connection in the face of digital alienation.

LOGLINE

The Owl House in Virtual Reality is a VR experience that transports audiences to a small South African town in the 1970s, where they explore a magical house and witness the defiant artistic collaboration between Helen Martins and Koos Malgas, two artists who transcended the racial tensions of Apartheid to create a unique pilgrimage site.

SYNOPSIS

The Owl House in VR offers users an interactive live museum tour and performance, transporting them to the Owl House in Nieu-Bethesda, South Africa. You'll step directly into a compelling story based on the lives of Helen Martins and Koos Malgas, extraordinary artists who defied 1970s Apartheid's rigid norms and racial tensions to create a magical pilgrimage site. As a ghost, users uncover a narrative that's both playful and tragic, witnessing Helen and Koos's idiosyncratic relationship and the profound tragedy of Helen's suicide. This story unfolds via virtual Koos and Helen acting out scenes, and through interactive letters, books, and poetry Helen left behind. Presented as a living archive and virtual tour, Koos's granddaughter, Julia Malgas, guides you, recounting childhood memories and prompting exploration for hidden items. This artistic rendition breathes life into the Owl House, restoring Helen, Koos, and their sculptures. Users witness sculptures coming to life, beginning their journey towards Mecca and enlightenment.



Jason Mollink,
Director



Lebo Leitch,
Producer

GOALS AND
PARTNERSHIPS
SOUGHT IN VENICE
To meet co-producers,
museums and financiers.

FORMAT / RUNTIME

VR CGI / 30' / 45'

Colour

BASED ON

The lives of artists Helen
Martins and Koos Malgas

LANGUAGES

South African English

BUDGET /

FINANCING IN PLACE

€ 97.000 /

€ 40.000

MAIN PRODUCTION

COMPANY
SodaWorld

CO-PRODUCTION

COMPANIES
XR Native

CREATIVE TEAM

Jason Mollink, *Director*
Ree Treweek, *Artistic Director*
Lebo Leitch, *Producer*

DELEGATE PRODUCTION

COMPANY
SodaWorld

MAIN CONTACT PERSON

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DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

Helen and Koos's relationship is endlessly fascinating to me. They blur the boundaries between artist and assistant, collaborator and friend. Their relationship reveals deeper complexities about relationships in South Africa. Tragedy comes to Helen and Koos in different ways. The circumstances of Helen's alienation for alternative artistic practice is of a different ilk to the alienation Koos is subjected to by the racism of the segregated world he lives in. The two find each other in shared alienation. Getting to know Koos through his granddaughter Julia has been very meaningful to my understanding of this story. My hope is that this experience breaks new ground for emotional narratives for underrepresented voices, both Helen and Koos's, as well as in the mixing of immersive film with archival practice. My aim is for this experience to weave together museum exploration with the novelty and excitement of video game exploration, bringing this narrative out of the depths of South African history and into the new light of new media.

PRODUCTION COMPANY PROFILE

SodaWorld is a South African immersive studio pioneering African storytelling through virtual and mixed reality. Founded by Mic Balkind during the pandemic, it has produced over 50 virtual experiences from its cutting-edge Johannesburg studio. With work featured at the Venice Film Festival and collaborations with cultural institutions like the Centre for the Less Good Idea, SodaWorld blends tech and storytelling to deliver bold, culturally rich narratives that resonate globally.

MAIN FILMOGRAPHY

OF PRODUCTION COMPANY

- 2025** *Tresor des Poubelles Ai + film*
by Nhlanhla Dhlamini
- 2024** *Dichipi* by Siyabonga Mkhize
- 2023** *Blue Whale AR Encounter*
- 2023** *Nature in Motion series* for Meta Horizons

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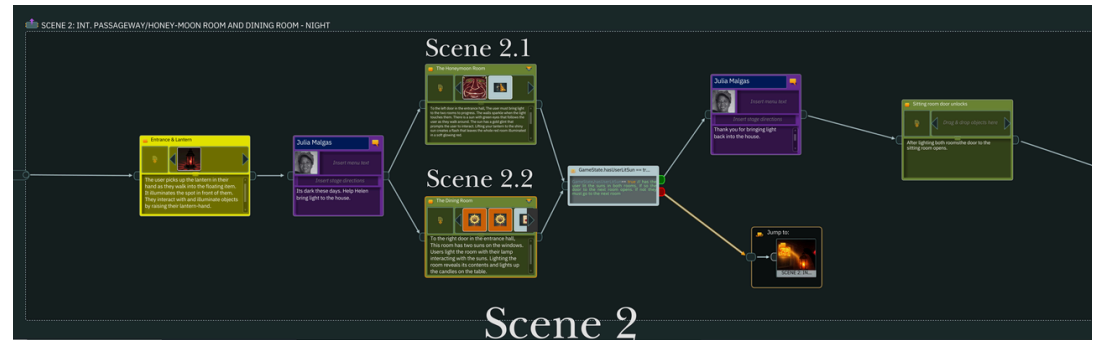
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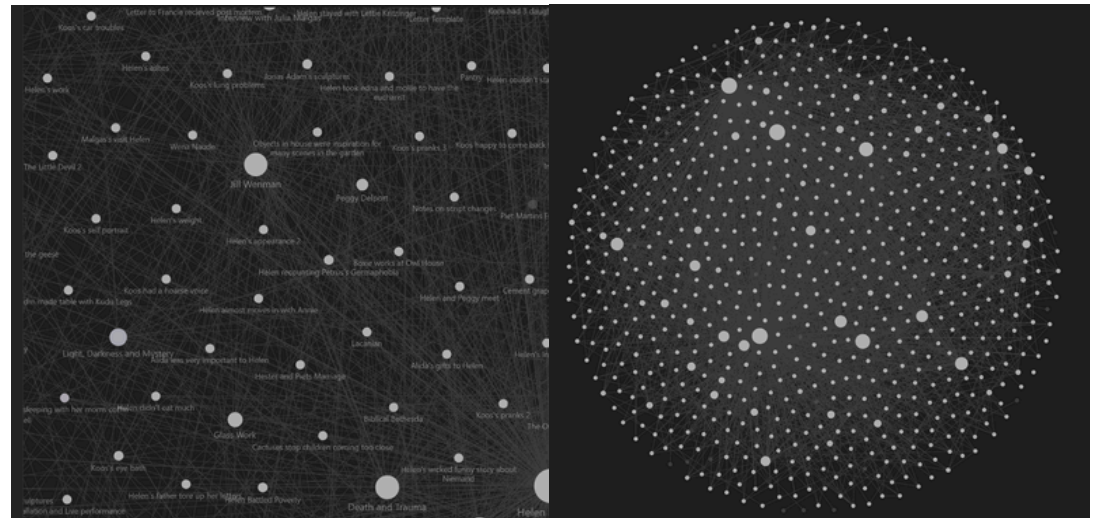
INTERACTIVE
NARRATIVE

The Owl House in VR

Continued...



Script written and coded into Articy:draft X for interactive game design.



Interactive research document with hundreds of entries written in Obsidian

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SHORT FILM

Psshhh or Liphi iKhaya Labo

A surreal odyssey into Cape Town's unconscious. A young real estate agent is invited out to the club. After being barred from entering because of his sneakers, he decides to take a pair of smart shiny shoes off a sleeping homeless man. Dark forces pursue him back in the club.

Premiered at the Joburg Underground Film Festival. Screened at Search Music Festival, Joburg Underground Film Festival, and the Gorgeous George Hotel, Cape Town.

EXT. COMPANY GARDENS — NIGHT

Homeless people sleep in pockets of light across the grass. Sibs spots figure — bottom half bathed in lamplight, sticking out from a blanket: pair of shining black derby shoes.

He steps closer. The body lies still as death. After a long moment, removes the man's shoes. Dirty grey socks beneath. He slips off his takkies, leaves them beside the man, puts the new shoes on.

Sibs gives a gentle, tentative smile. A soft whisper breaks the quiet

VOICE

Hey skelm.

Other whispers join. They overlap, amalgamate, become a heavy hissing. Sibs breathes heavily, looks around. Wide-eyed. Frantic. All he sees darkness.

EXT. STREET — NIGHT

Sibs is running. A hand shoots out from an alleyway and pulls him in. The homeless man. He presses a finger to his lips.

HOMELESS MAN

Shhhhhh.

A shot of their feet. Sibs in black derby shoes. The man in Sibs' old New Balances. The man gestures gently down the dark alleyway and takes Sibs by the hand.

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SHORT FILM **Rhodes House**

The ghosts of Cecil John Rhodes and Jan Smuts haunt an unsuspecting housemate in an old mansion in Cape Town.

Premiered at the Joburg Underground Film Festival.

INT. LIVING ROOM — DAY

Cecil and Jan leaf through old photo albums. Jan's hands rest warmly on Cecil's shoulders.

JAN

We've been haunting this place for eone!

CECIL

Eons, yes. It's been a long time. But I couldn't imagine myself happier anywhere else.

JAN

I do wish we could get along better with Alex, to be honest.

INT. ALEX'S ROOM — DAY [INTERVIEW]

Alex sits alone in front of the camera.

ALEX

Yeah, I was not expecting colonial conquerors for roommates. But that's the price of these luxury houses, I guess.

He shows us ghost-cam footage on his laptop: Jan tickles Alex's nose with a feather duster. Cecil restrains a laugh behind him.

ALEX

They're fucking assholes, honestly.

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WEB - SERIES

Chief Poop Officer

A lowly corporate employee is offered a bizarre path up the ladder: become his company's Chief Poop Officer — overseeing a scheme that exploits parental leave in the most surreal ways imaginable.

INT. OFFICE KITCHEN — DAY

Jack looks around the room trying to avoid eye contact with Babalwa, who sits across from him at the table. The sound of suckling. She is breastfeeding a white child. Jack takes a quick look and stares into the corner.

JACK

Um, I'm just going to the bathroom.

INT. WOMEN'S BATHROOM — DAY

Pitch black. Babalwa flicks the lights on. Twelve round shallow plastic buckets stand in two rows of six on the floor. Jack and Babalwa each hold a baby.

Babalwa gently dunks the first baby. It comes out crying. She holds up to the fluorescent light.

BABALWA

Christopher.

She repeats. One by one. Thando. Lucy. Grace. Jacob. Carl. Kiara. Henno. Mimi. Abdul. Bonica. Bronwyn.

Babalwa nods. She turns. Throws water in Jack's face.

BABALWA

Jack.

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SHORT FILM

Calypso

Upcoming film currently seeking development funding: Shoka and Thando live tedious lives in Randburg suburbia. A crack appears in their world when Calypso comes back. They're not quite sure what is about him. He seems to possess everything. A seducer with tall tales and a baleful of charisma. When Calypso does arrive, time seems to speed up. One moment they're outside, the next they're inside and then they're somewhere else entirely. If they think hard about it, something feels quite off. Maybe it is the rotating spirals that fill Calypso's eyes. Maybe it is the Calypso's unwavering Cheshire Cat smile. They're slipping out of their comfort zone and losing grip of what's real. It's Calypso's world they're in now and they're spiralling.

Calypso is still smiling ear to ear. Tshepo's hand slowly encroaches on a vape that's slightly out of reach. The vape has a screen with a temperature gauge. He can see his reflection in it. A spiral appears on that screen as well.

THANDO

Skyf?

The vape spins along the floor and lands by Thando's head. He takes a big hit and his eyes open wide.

CUT TO:

INT. PASSAGEWAY NEXT TO HIS BATHROOM - DAY

Thando's hand violently pushes open his bedroom door. His breath is shallow and hoarse. He waddles through to the bathroom. Tshepo and Calypso are sitting up on the carpet. Calypso is still smiling.

TSHEPO

Yoh Umfanaka what's up?

Thando breathes harshly while his hands clutch the toilet bowl. A spiral swirls around the toilet too. Thando's eyes do the same.

CUT TO:

EXT: VIDEO GAME

Thando has been scanned into a video game. He walks by kicking a football with his right foot, moving through a field with patches of shrubbery. Fog surrounds everything and not much can be seen in the distance. He stumbles upon a well. In the well is a giant eye ball which ticks back and forth like a clock. Thando peers down to look at it. His face is unmoving. Behind him appear five sheep with white coats and black faces. Thando moves to let them go past. One by one, they jump into the well.

An egg spins gently as it falls down a dark shaft. It lands at the surface and cracks, revealing an eyeball that rolls around.

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THEORETICAL DISSERTATION

How to Kill Images

Dissertation drawing on Agamben, Debord, Lacan, and Dayan. Argues that our relationship with images is constitutively violent — and that the image always survives.

1. Don Quixote's Imagination

Georgio Agamben names his final chapter in *Profanations*, "The Six Most Beautiful Minutes in the History of Cinema" in dedication to a scene from Orson Welles's never finished *Don Quixote*. The scene is difficult to find and see. It is almost extinct, a metastasised part of a dying film. The fragment I found on YouTube was blurry and full of artefacts. The frames hop and jump around as if they have stage fright about being exhibited. There is no sound, just imagery. I've taken from it a screenshot which appears only for an instance, of a crucified Jesus projected onto the screen. In front is Don Quixote, just risen from his seat to slash out at the image with his sword. There is a void in Jesus's lower half where the Don has ripped the projection sheet. The scene begins as Don Quixote's squire, Sancho Panza, searches for his master in the movie theatre. He makes an effort to sit next to him but the theatre is too packed and he sits next to a little girl. Agamben figures her to be Don Quixote's fated lover, Dulcinea. It is guess work because the scene is never included into the larger narrative. In the novel, Dulcinea is the woman of Don Quixote's dreams. He makes her up to be his lover to fulfil his own chivalric requirement to have a beautiful woman. She doesn't exist in the book but it would be apt for Welles to place her here because this is a scene about the Don and his imagination. It turns out she is not a woman at all. The only person who fits the Don's virtues of virginity and innocence is a child. Don Quixote doesn't notice this, or her; he is completely transfixed by the screen. Recognition of her by Don Quixote, or even by Welles, would mean she could break out of the confines of imagination. But the Don's imagination is on hyper drive and he seems unable to keep it from impinging on the real world. The events on screen are intensifying. He sees a woman in danger as knights encircle her. The Don can't take it anymore and gets up to kill the image. Bewildered by the number of events and characters flying past, he starts swinging indiscriminately. He only manages to hit out at his own shadow blocking the projector.

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INTERACTIVE NARRATIVE **The Blank Eye Cinema**

A virtual cinema space accessible via web-browser where live audiences watch films together as avatars in a social videogame. The cinema specialises in Pan-African and experimental films made in collaboration with Johannesburg-based Immersive Studio SodaWorld. I was the director and designer of the virtual world, managing a world builder who created the space between February and April 2025. Images show examples of my copy written to appear in the video game environment.

Funded by HTC's Viverse.

